Integrated Marketing Campaign (IMC)

Event Resource Guide

Prepared in partnership with

Adobe



OVERVIEW

The DECA Integrated Marketing Campaign (IMC) Guide was created in collaboration with Adobe and is designed to help students develop and pitch a compelling, insight-driven marketing campaign aligned with real-world business challenges.

It walks through each phase of campaign development, from research and strategic planning to creative execution and final presentation, providing students with structure, expectations, and best practices.

This guide includes input from Adobe employees who specialize in campaign strategy and design, agency management, and marketing technology to ensure a real-world, professional approach. Grounded in industry-relevant terminology and presentation standards, it empowers students to think critically, act collaboratively, and communicate persuasively—essential skills for careers in marketing, advertising, or public relations. Whether you're new to DECA or preparing for competition, this guide serves as your roadmap to building a standout campaign.

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PHASE 0:
GETTING STARTED

Setting up the competition and foundational project work

DECA x Adobe



PHASE 0

Getting Started

Summary of the DECA Competition

A DECA Integrated Marketing Campaign (IMC) is a competitive event where high school students develop and present a comprehensive marketing strategy for a product, service, or event. The goal is to show how various marketing tactics and channels come together to deliver a unified, effective campaign.

First place teams at **DECA**'s International Career Development Conference (ICDC) that demonstrate significant use of Adobe Express in their pitch deck and presentation **will earn $5,000 per team**. Following ICDC, these teams will engage in a 5–10-minute, live Zoom call to showcase the impact of using Adobe Express in their project and participate in Q&A.



Campaign Types:

DECA offers three IMC categories:

- **Event:** Promote a specific event (e.g., concert, fundraiser).
- **Product:** Market a tangible item (e.g., tech gadget, clothing line).
- **Service:** Promote an intangible offering (e.g., tutoring, pet grooming).

Team Size:

1 to 3 participants

Deliverables:

- A **pitch deck** outlining the campaign
- A **15-minute presentation** to a judge simulating a real-world pitch
- Cluster exam

Key Elements:

- Clear target market
- Consistent messaging across platforms
- Use of digital and traditional media
- Budget and timeline planning
- Measurable objectives and evaluation methods

Benefits to Students

This event helps students build real-world skills in:

- Strategic thinking
- Creative communication
- Market research
- Team collaboration
- Public speaking

Project Requirements

- Develop a campaign that spans no more than 45 days
- Submit a pitch deck
- Prepare a presentation (up to 15 minutes) for a judge in a role-play scenario (judge plays prospective client)

Classroom Integration Note: Preparing for the Marketing Cluster Exam

In addition to the written campaign and presentation, students participating in DECA's Integrated Marketing Campaign event will complete a Marketing Cluster Exam. This multiple-choice exam tests foundational marketing knowledge, including:

- The 4Ps of Marketing
- Market segmentation and targeting
- Branding and positioning
- Pricing strategies
- Channels of distribution
- Promotional tactics

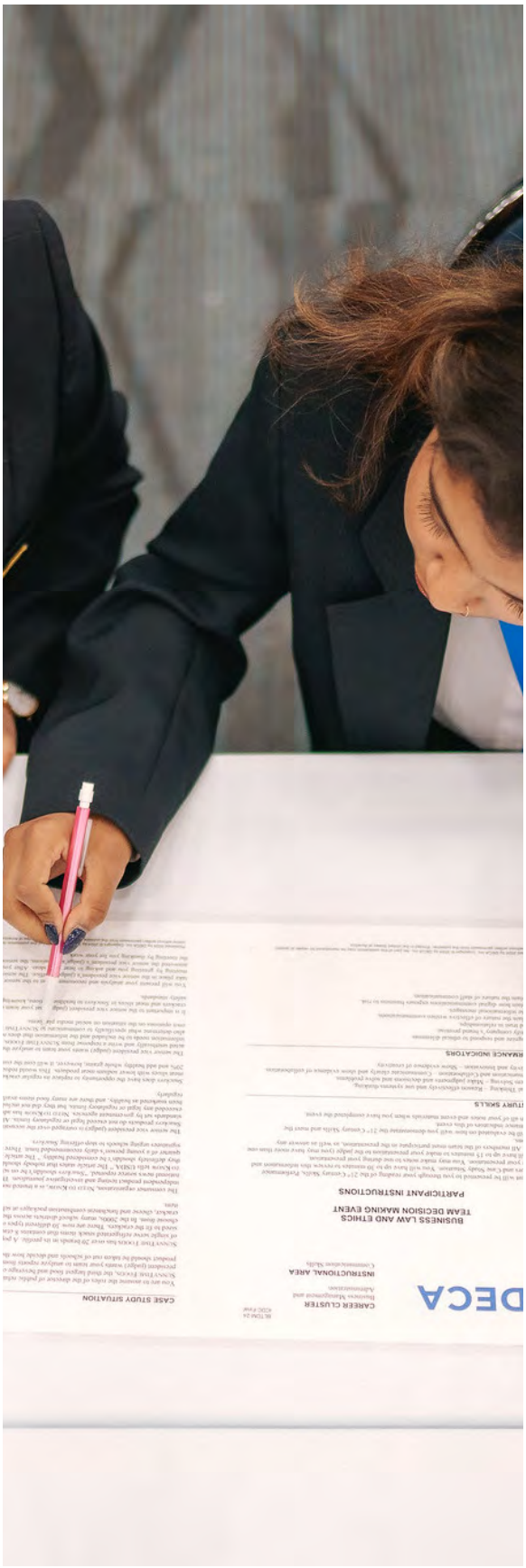
Suggested Integration Tips

Weekly review: Dedicate 10–15 minutes each week to revisiting core marketing principles, tied to the project phase.

Concept mapping: Ask students to link their IMC strategy decisions (e.g., objectives, audience research, promotional mix) to corresponding concepts that could appear on the exam.

Practice questions: Use sample questions from DECA or MBA Research as warm-ups or quiz games.

Pair with Phase 1 of this guide: Reinforce strong campaigns are rooted in solid marketing fundamentals, the same concepts the exam evaluates.





PHASE 0

INDUSTRY POINT OF VIEW:

The Role of AI in Professional Marketing

Just as AI is reshaping education, it is also transforming how businesses operate, especially in marketing. From personalized content to automated insights, AI tools are becoming essential in how brands connect with customers.

Teaching students about AI in marketing helps them understand where, how, and why it's used, while also encouraging awareness of its limitations—such as bias, privacy concerns, and overdependence on automation. By exploring both the opportunities and challenges of AI, students will be better prepared to use it responsibly and effectively in real-world marketing roles.

In Phase 2: Campaign Planning, this guide will dive deeper into the use of AI for developing creative designs.

Resource:

Adobe's Creativity and AI in Education 2025 Report offers valuable insights into how fostering creativity in the classroom can enhance academic achievement, career readiness, and personal growth for students.

What is AI in Marketing?

AI in marketing refers to the use of artificial intelligence technologies, such as machine learning (ML), natural language processing (NLP), and generative AI, to automate, personalize, and optimize marketing efforts. It enables marketers to make data-driven decisions, create content at scale, and deliver hyper-personalized experiences.



Audience segmentation - AI analyzes customer data to create precise, dynamic audience groups that meet campaign requirements.



Content creation - Generative AI tools produce copy, images, and videos based on prompts.



Email personalization - AI can personalize emails and provide content recommendations to support higher engagement.



Media buying - AI optimizes advertising budgets by predicting the best channels and timing.



Customer engagement - Chatbots and AI assistants provide real-time, personalized support.



Predictive analytics - AI forecasts customer behavior and campaign outcomes.



Performance tracking - AI-enabled dashboards provide data-based insights on content and channel performance.



Strategic Benefits

- **Speed and scale:** Accelerate campaign execution and scale personalization across channels.
- **Efficiency:** Automate repetitive tasks like A/B testing, reporting, and content tagging.
- **Insight:** Surface actionable insights from vast datasets, improving decision-making.
- **ROI optimization:** Enhance targeting and conversion through smarter segmentation and timing.

What students should know about AI:

- AI is a tool to support learning, not a shortcut.
- Use AI to summarize notes, brainstorm, and organize ideas.
- Ask clear, specific questions for better results.
- Always double check AI-generated content for accuracy.
- Respect academic integrity; don't use AI to cheat.
- Protect your privacy; avoid sharing personal info.

Teaching Framework

What it means: AI skills will be important in every industry, not just technology fields, and preparing students to enter the modern. workforce means creating an essential foundation for students to know how AI works, how to use this technology responsibly, and how to navigate an AI-powered world.

Why it matters:

- AI can save time by summarizing plans and generating materials.
- Teach AI literacy; how it works, benefits, and risks.
- Use AI to differentiate instruction and personalize learning
- Model ethical AI use in classroom scenarios.
- Stay informed with resources like TeachAI and OSPI guidance.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Use the following topics as prompts to discuss the ethical considerations of using AI.

- **Importance of transparency:** Be clear when content is AI-generated.
- **Discuss bias mitigation:** Regularly audit AI models for fairness.
- **Discuss privacy:** Ensure compliance with data protection regulations.



PHASE 0

GUIDING STUDENTS TO SELECT A CAMPAIGN TOPIC

Help students choose a campaign topic that sets them up for success by balancing passion, feasibility, and alignment with the DECA IMC rubric. Use the criteria below to lead classroom discussions, brainstorm sessions, or one-on-one check-ins.

The agency leader for this phase of the work is the Business Development Manager, supported by the Account Manager. If you jump ahead to the next section, Create and Staff Your Agency, there is more information about these roles.

1. Personal Interest and Passion

Encourage students to choose a topic they genuinely care about. Whether it's a local nonprofit, a tech gadget, or a peer-run tutoring service, their enthusiasm will come through in both their campaign development and final pitch.

2. Relevance and Realism

Students should select a topic that could logically be marketed within their local community and realistically executed within the 45-day campaign timeline.

3. Audience Clarity

Support students in identifying a specific and clearly defined target audience. A focused audience—like parents, students, pet owners, or local business owners—will help shape effective messaging and media choices.

4. Marketing Potential

Guide students to ideas with room for creative promotion across multiple channels. Strong topics allow for a mix of media types, such as social, print, events, or partnerships (and an integrated marketing campaign should include multiple channels). Example topics:

- **Event:** Fundraiser, sports tournament, community concert
- **Product:** Eco-friendly water bottle, student planner, snack
- **Service:** Pet grooming, tutoring, car wash

5. Creativity and Differentiation

Push students to think about how their idea will stand out. Can they offer a unique spin, creative branding concept, or visual identity that makes their campaign more memorable?

6. Research Availability

Remind students to consider whether they'll be able to find enough background material to support their plan such as pricing, competitors, customer insights, tone of voice, or marketing channel data.

7. Alignment with DECA Guidelines

Before students lock in their idea, have them review the DECA IMC rubric and official event guidelines to ensure their topic fits within the requirements for the written entry, presentation, and campaign scope.

Teaching Tips

Introduce students to tools they can use for brainstorming and collaboration. These support both creativity and accountability across team roles.

- **Miro Board** – Visual collaboration for idea mapping
- **Adobe Express** – Quick visuals, posters, brand kit, and social content



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Have students create a visual canvas to brainstorm and refine their project topic.

Start with a board of favorite ideas, themes, interests, companies, or trending topics. Have students consider:

- Is there enough information online about your topic?
- Is there too much information?
- Is the topic too broad?
- Do you see any patterns or recurring themes in what interests you?

End the exercise with teams selecting their IMC project.



PHASE 0

CREATE AND STAFF YOUR AGENCY TEAM

Begin the project by helping students set up their mock advertising agency team. Assigning key roles early on encourages shared leadership and helps students approach their work as a real agency team would. This structure supports collaboration, accountability, and clarity of responsibilities.

With small groups, or if a student is working independently, they will need to take on multiple roles throughout the project. Use the role descriptions and project phase mapping provided in this guide to help teams divide responsibilities effectively and stay organized across each phase of the campaign.

Overview of agency roles:

Role	What They Do	Best For Someone Who Is...
Business Development Manager	Finds new clients and opportunities; pitches ideas and communicates your agency's value.	Outgoing, persuasive, confident, and future focused.
Account Manager	Main contact for the client; ensures the team meets goals and keeps the project on track.	Friendly, organized, and a strong communicator.
Strategist	Uses research and insights to guide the campaign strategy; understanding the audience and what motivates them.	Curious, analytical, and good at solving problems.
Project Manager	Keeps the team organized and on schedule; manages tasks and deadlines.	Detail-oriented, calm under pressure, and loves planning.
Creative Director	Leads the creative vision; leads the copywriter and art director to bring ideas to life.	Big-picture thinker, creative, and confident giving feedback.
Copywriter	Writes headlines, scripts, and other content that fits the brand's voice.	A strong writer, clever with words, and good at storytelling.
Art Director	Designs the look—layouts, colors, visuals—based on the brand and audience.	Visually creative, detail-focused, and works well with others.
Media Planner	Decides where and when ads should run to reach the right audience.	Strategic, data-savvy, and tuned in to trends.
Event Planner	Plans events like launches or pop-ups, handling logistics and details.	Outgoing, organized, and great at multitasking.
Web Designer/ Developer	Designs and builds websites or digital tools that are user-friendly and on-brand.	Tech-savvy, creative, and a good problem-solver.



Teaching Tips

- Encourage students to select roles based on both interest and emerging strengths. This is an opportunity for skill-building and exploration.
- Emphasize that roles are flexible. Teams do not need to assign one person per role. Promote shared responsibility, inclusive brainstorming, and cross-functional collaboration.
- Use roles as an organizing tool to structure the work. Reinforce that major decisions, such as campaign direction or presentation flow, should be made collectively.
- Highlight how rotating leadership opportunities across phases can help students build confidence in different aspects of the project.
- Remind students that a compelling pitch showcases both a strong creative idea and the team's ability to collaborate effectively.
- To promote cross-team collaboration, consider positioning the whole class or club as a single agency, with different teams assigned to different brand accounts, but all working to win projects that will make the agency successful. This mirrors how real agencies operate and when one team is successful on a pitch, the whole agency benefits.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Activity 1:

Explore careers in advertising and marketing by researching role responsibilities, qualifications, and career paths.

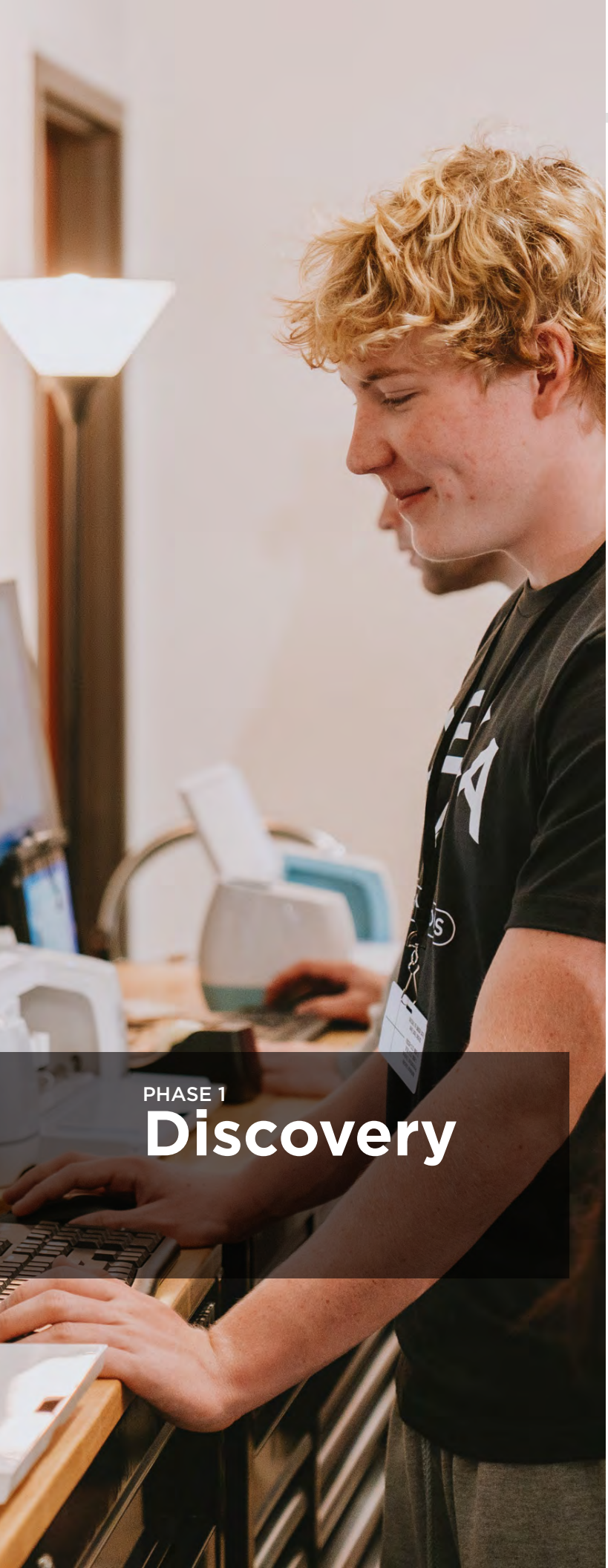
Activity 2:

Use personality assessments (e.g., Myers-Briggs, Adobe Creative Types) to help students understand their strengths, how to work together, and assign team roles.

PHASE 1: **DISCOVERY**

Building a Strategic Foundation

DECA x Adobe



PHASE 1

Discovery

The discovery phase helps students build the foundational knowledge necessary to create an insight-driven integrated marketing campaign. Through structured research and strategic thinking, students will learn how to explore an industry, evaluate a brand, analyze competitors, and understand the target audience, all culminating in a Campaign Brief.

This section includes 4 parts:

1. Research and understand the industry and brand
2. Identify the business challenges and your project objectives
3. Build your understanding of the target audience
4. Document your insights in a campaign brief

The agency leader for this phase of the work is the Strategist. When this section is complete, students will have the information needed to draft the following information for their pitch deck:

- Description of the event, product or service and its company
- Campaign objectives
- Campaign target market



PHASE 1

UNDERSTANDING THE INDUSTRY AND BRAND THROUGH RESEARCH

Once students select a project, this phase focuses on building a deep understanding of the industry and the brand's current market positioning. This foundational knowledge will guide campaign strategy and execution.

Key Definitions

- **Industry:** A group of companies offering similar products or services.
- **Brand:** The identity of a business, product, or service as perceived by the public including its name, logo, values, reputation, and overall image.
- **Competitive set:** A subset of the industry; brands that compete for the same target audience.
- **Market positioning:** How a brand is perceived in relation to its competitors.
- **SWOT analysis:** A framework for identifying a brand's:
  - **Strengths and Weaknesses:** internal factors within the company's control
  - **Opportunities and Threats:** external factors shaped by market or industry forces
- **USP (Unique selling proposition):** The brand's distinct advantage or benefit that sets it apart from competitors.

Teaching Framework

What it means: Research is the foundation of any strong campaign and pitch. Students will investigate the real-world environment their brand operates in and develop expertise in the brand's business and competitive landscape.

Why it matters: Clients expect agencies to understand their business thoroughly and to present a campaign grounded in real audience needs, market trends, and actionable insights.

Examples of research activities:

- General company background research
- SWOT analysis
- Competitive review

Teaching tips

- Use the classroom activities below to help students conduct structured research on their chosen brand. Emphasize the importance of completing this foundational work before jumping into campaign planning or creative development. It builds confidence and ensures the final campaign strategy is relevant and effective.
- For larger companies, students can use official brand websites, corporate blogs, and annual or quarterly reports to gather accurate information. For smaller or local businesses where less information is publicly available, encourage students to conduct informational interviews with management to better understand their goals, challenges, and market position.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

These assignments will help students develop key knowledge of their client and the industry they exist in.

Activity 1: Conduct general company research.

Summarize the industry trends, describe the brand's history, mission, and study any recent marketing initiatives.

Example: if researching Adobe, students can find company history and mission information on the corporate About Adobe webpage and see marketing campaigns live on Adobe's social media sites or corporate blog. For trends, they might search for external articles on the future of software and creative industries or on specific trends (e.g. The rise of AI for content creation).

Activity 2: Create a SWOT analysis for your selected brand.

Include at least three points for each category with supporting research or rationale. Encourage students to use real data to support claims.

Example: for a small local coffee shop one example of each could be:

Strength	Weakness
Loyal local customer base; 45% of sales come from members of rewards program.	Limited digital presence; website last updated in 2023
Opportunity	**Threat**
Rising demand for mobile ordering; per Statistica, mobile food ordering is expected to grow 9.49% from 2024 to 2029.	Expansion of national chains; per Toast research, national chains had a growth rate of 8% in 2024.

Activity 3: Conduct a competitive review.

Choose two competitors of your selected brand. Compare how they all position themselves and market their products. This can include analyzing competitors' messaging and creative style alongside comparing websites, social media use, and advertising channels to understand where their brand and project can stand out.

Example: if studying Apple and planning a campaign to support the launch of a new iPhone, students might review Samsung and Google's recent phone launches.



PHASE 1

THE BUSINESS CHALLENGE AND PROJECT OBJECTIVES

Once students have developed a foundational understanding of the industry and brand, they must identify the main business challenge their campaign aims to solve and define what success looks like.

Key Definitions

- **Business challenge:** A gap, obstacle, or unmet need the brand faces that marketing can help address.
- **Marketing objective:** A specific, measurable result the campaign aims to achieve (e.g., increased awareness, sales, or engagement).
- **SMART goals:** Goals that are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.



Teaching Framework

A. Business Challenge

- **What it means:** What is limiting the brand's success? Based on research, this could be low awareness, a shift in customer behavior, weak engagement, increased competition, or another issue.
- **Why it matters:** Identifying the core challenge helps students develop strategic and actionable marketing objectives.
- **Example:** "How can a local bookstore drive more in-store foot traffic during weekdays?"
- **Teaching tip:** Consider having students frame the challenge as a question—it encourages open-ended thinking and serves as a prompt for the next project phase.

B. Marketing Objective

- **What it means:** This is the goal that the campaign should achieve in response to the business challenge.
- **Why it matters:** Clearly defined, SMART-style objectives provide focus for the campaign and will give students a framework to evaluate whether their campaign is successful.
- **Example:** "Increase weekday store visits by 15% within three months of campaign launch."
- **Teaching tip:** Keep objectives high-level and strategic. Tactics to achieve them like events or social posts will come in later phases.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Activity 1: Review brand research and identify one significant business challenge.

Encourage students to frame this as a guiding question.

Activity 2: Review SMART goals with students and ask them to write a SMART marketing objective directly tied to the business challenge for their campaign.

Discuss how their objective does or does not meet the requirements of a SMART goal. Note: Objectives should be measurable by real metrics the brand would have access to and should not include campaign tactics yet.



PHASE 1

UNDERSTANDING THE TARGET AUDIENCE

A strong understanding of the target audience helps students shape messages, creative design, and platform choices that are both relevant and effective.

Key Definitions

- **Target audience:** The group the campaign aims to influence.
- **Persona:** A fictional character based on research that represents the audience.
- **Demographics:** Statistical traits (e.g., age, income, gender, location).
- **Psychographics:** Values, beliefs, interests, and motivations.
- **Media habits:** How and where the audience consumes content.

Teaching Framework

What it means: Students create detailed audience profiles based on research, including values, behaviors, needs, and pain points.

Why it matters: The more students understand the target audience, the better they can craft relevant, compelling campaigns.

Example of a Persona:

- **Name:** Busy Brianna
- **Age:** 36
- **Lifestyle:** Working mom of two, always multitasking
- **Interests:** Time-saving tips, mobile shopping
- **Media habits:** Podcasts during commutes, shops on Instagram
- **Needs:** Convenience, fast solutions
- **Motivation:** Eco-conscious
- **Barrier:** Unsure which brands are genuinely sustainable

Teaching tip: Encourage students to think beyond "who they are" to understand "why they act" and what motivates or holds back their audience.



Busy Brianna

AGE	35–45
LIFESTYLE	Working mom of two, always multitasking
INTERESTS	Time-saving tips, mobile shopping
MEDIA HABITS	Podcasts during commutes, shops on Instagram
NEEDS	Convenience, fast solutions
MOTIVATION	Eco-conscious
BARRIER	Unsure which brands are genuinely sustainable



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Activity 1: Have students create a detailed audience persona.

This should include name, age, location, lifestyle, interests, media habits, motivations, and potential barriers. Students should use real data (e.g., Pew Research) supported by qualitative input like interviews with real people.

Activity 2 (Bonus - Senior Build):

If students identify multiple personas, guide them to define a primary and secondary audience.



PHASE 1

DEVELOPING A CAMPAIGN BRIEF

The campaign brief synthesizes research findings into a one-page strategic blueprint for creative and tactical planning.

Key Definitions

- **Campaign brief:** A concise document outlining the strategy and direction for the campaign.
- **Insight:** A deep human truth about the audience that informs messaging and tone.
- **Tone and voice:** The style and personality of brand communication.
- **CTA (Call to Action):** The action you want the audience to take.
- **Media channels:** Platforms used to reach the audience (e.g., social media, radio, podcasts).



A campaign brief should include the following sections:

- Background and business challenge
- Target audience and persona summary
- Key insight
- Marketing objectives
- Core message / Unique selling proposition (USP)
- Tone and creative direction
- Media channels to consider
- CTA (Call to Action)

Teaching Framework

What it means: Students translate discovery-phase research into a clear, actionable brief.

Why it matters: A well-structured brief ensures alignment across the team and guides the creative and tactical planning to follow.

Examples:

- **Insight:** Young professionals feel overwhelmed by financial planning and crave simple, mobile-first solutions.
- **USP:** "App X offers one-click budgeting tailored for life on the go."
- **Tone:** Friendly, non-judgmental, supportive

Teaching tip: Consider creating a Campaign Brief template. Frame this assignment as a handoff from research to creative development.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

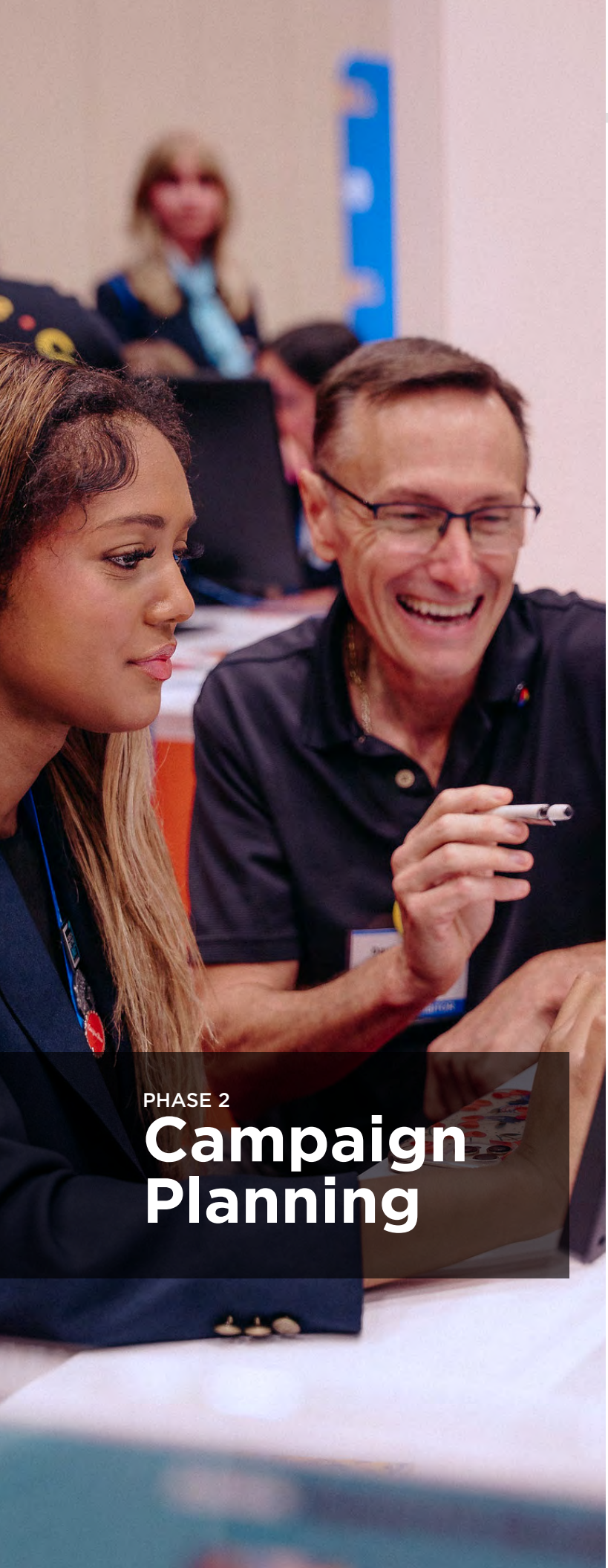
Have students draft a campaign brief using their findings from the Discovery phase.

The brief should reflect strategic thinking and set a clear foundation for creative development. Encourage students to label each section clearly and back it with insights. This document will be a reference point for evaluating creative work and selecting channels in later phases.

PHASE 2:
CAMPAIGN PLANNING

Connecting Strategy to Execution

DECA x Adobe



PHASE 2

Campaign Planning

This is where students connect strategy to execution. By now they should have: a defined business challenge, an audience insight, and supporting research. In Campaign Planning, they transform that thinking into an integrated, creative, resourced, and measurable marketing plan they can pitch.

The agency leader for this phase of the work is the Creative Director, supported by the Art Director and Copywriter.



PHASE 2

DEVELOPING A CREATIVE BIG IDEA

The Creative Big Idea is the central, unifying concept that connects the brand's goal to the audience's need or desire. It should be insight-led, emotionally resonant, on-brand, and scalable across multiple formats and channels. A strong Big Idea gives the campaign cohesion and impact.

Principles of a Strong Creative Big Idea

A. Insight-Driven

What it means: Rooted in a research-based or cultural truth about the audience, category, or moment often revealing unmet needs or emotional tensions ("I want X but feel Y").

Why it matters: Ensures relevance and authenticity; prevents clever-but-empty ideas.

Example: Gen Z fatigue with filtered perfection fueled demand for more authentic social posting core to BeReal's growth narrative and positioning as the "anti-Instagram."

Teaching tip: Ask students to complete this sentence: "Our audience __, but __." The second blank often uncovers the insight.

B. Emotionally Resonant

What it means: The idea evokes a specific emotion like pride, urgency, joy, hope, or connection.

Why it matters: Emotion drives attention, recall, and action, especially with youth audiences.

Example: Dove's "Courage is Beautiful" honored exhausted frontline workers with unretouched portraits—an emotional, gratitude-led expression that deepened brand trust during a global crisis.

Teaching tip: Ask, "What should your audience feel when they see this campaign?" Students should select one primary emotion.

C. Brand-Aligned

What it means: The idea reflects the brand's values, tone, and mission, even if creatively bold.

Why it matters: Consistency builds long-term brand trust. Misalignment creates confusion.

Example: e.l.f.'s wild TikTok virality (#eyeslipsface) didn't happen by accident, it amplified the brand's inclusive, playful, "for every eye, lip & face" positioning in a Gen Z-native environment.

Teaching tip: Review the brand's mission and have students connect their idea to 2–3 keywords from it.

D. Simple but Scalable

What it means: Easily understood but flexible enough to extend across formats like short-form video, merchandise, events, and social assets.

Why it matters: Strong ideas should live beyond a single execution.

Example: Nike's "Play New" reframed success as trying, not winning—easy to communicate in copy, film, social challenges, and even interactive AR extensions.

Teaching tip: Ask students to explain their idea in 10 words, then show 3 ways it could appear: a sticker, a headline, and a 6-second video.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Activity 1: Each team receives a one-sentence insight and must generate three Big Ideas (headline-length) in 10 minutes.

The class votes on which best reflects the insight, which mirrors how a team might rely on other teams within their agency to provide feedback.

Activity 2 (Bonus - Senior Build):

Teams choose their best idea and write a short Campaign Narrative: the insight, desired emotion, brand linkage, and three platform executions (static, video, IRL/activation).

Student slide requirements:

- Campaign name / tagline
- 1–2 sentence idea statement tied to insight
- Visual mock / mood board
- Callout labels: Insight ⇨Idea ⇨Emotion ⇨ Brand Tie



PHASE 2

CREATIVE CONCEPTING: FROM INSIGHT TO EXECUTION

Now that students have a strong Big Idea, it's time to evolve it into a full campaign concept with visuals and messaging that bring it to life.

What is a Creative Concept?

It's the executional expression of the Big Idea—a story or theme that guides how the campaign looks, sounds, and performs.

It should:

- Reflect the audience insight
- Address the business challenge
- Be memorable, relevant, and emotionally engaging

See examples of real-world campaigns here:
https://business.adobe.com/blog/basics/marketing-campaign-examples



PHASE 2

CREATING VISUALS THAT BRING THE IDEA TO LIFE

Once the concept is defined, students should begin visualizing how it will come to life. This includes:

- Mood boards to capture tone, color, and style.
- Sample social posts, posters, or digital ads that reflect the campaign's look and feel.
- Mockups of how the campaign might appear in real-world settings (e.g., billboards, Instagram stories, or event signage).

Best Practices

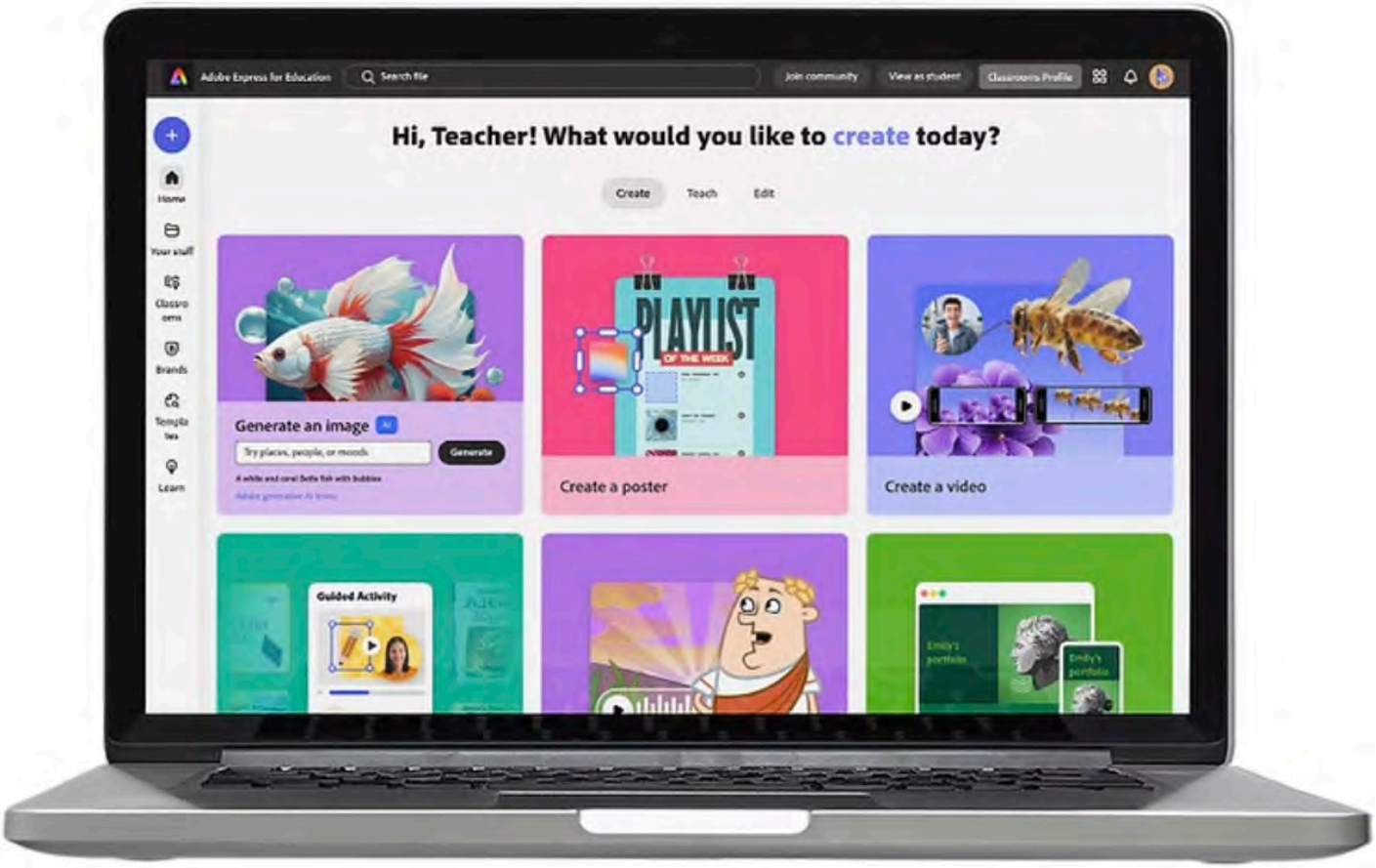
- Keep visuals consistent with the brand's identity.
- Use contrast, hierarchy, and whitespace to make designs clear and engaging.
- Ensure accessibility; consider color contrast and font readability.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Mood board + Mockup Challenge to teach students how to visually express a campaign idea.

- Students select one of their creative concepts.
- Using Adobe Express, create a mood board that reflects the tone, color palette, and style of the campaign.
- Then, they design one mockup asset (e.g., Instagram post, flyer, or poster).



PHASE 2

USING ADOBE EXPRESS FOR VISUAL DEVELOPMENT

Adobe Express is a powerful, student-friendly tool for creating campaign visuals. It offers:

- Templates for social media, posters, flyers, pitch decks and more.
- Brand kits to maintain visual consistency.
- Quick actions like background removal, animation, and resizing for different platforms.

How to Use It:

- Adobe Express Tutorials & Guided Activities (template + video tutorial + instructions)
- Start with a template and customize it with campaign colors, fonts, and imagery.
- Apply a consistent look across all campaign assets.
- Export assets in multiple formats for use in the pitch deck or mock campaign rollout.

Resource:

Learn more about Adobe's commitment to classroom-ready AI for students and teachers.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

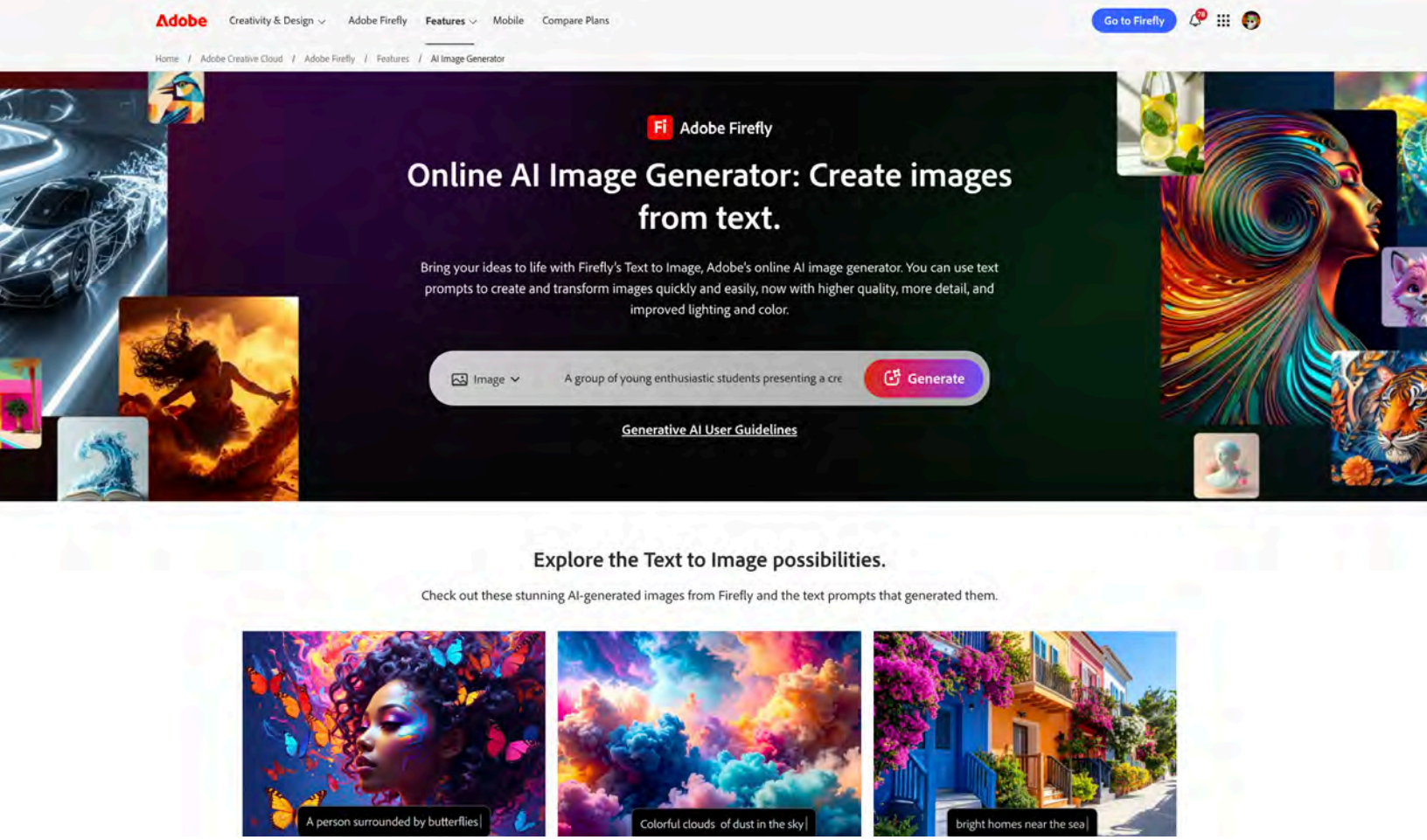
Activity 1: Adobe Express Design Sprint to familiarize students with Adobe Express tools and workflows.

- Provide a short tutorial or demo on Adobe Express features (templates, brand kits, quick actions).
- Instructors to assign a predefined mini-brief to students (e.g., “Design a social post for a back-to-school campaign”).
- Students use Adobe Express to create and export their design.

Activity 2: Encourage students to create a brand kit in Adobe Express for their campaign and apply it across multiple assets.

Adobe Express resources for teachers:

- Importance of Creativity (classroom posters)
- Classrooms, Community, and Creativity - Learn course (earn your ACE badge!)
- Professional Development Catalog
- Adobe Express Demo Accounts



PHASE 2

HOW AI CAN ASSIST IN THE CREATIVE PROCESS

AI tools can help students ideate, iterate, and refine their creative work. Here is how:

- **Idea generation:** Use AI writing tools to brainstorm headlines, taglines, or campaign themes.
- **Image generation:** Tools like Adobe Firefly can create custom visuals from text prompts.
- **Design suggestions:** Adobe Express uses AI to recommend layouts, fonts, and color palettes based on your content.

Generative AI considerations for students:

- Use AI as a collaborator, not a crutch. Always review and refine outputs.
- Be aware of ethical considerations; do not try to pass off AI-generated work entirely as your own.
- Use AI to brainstorm and explore multiple directions, then choose the best one(s) to evaluate further.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Activity 1: AI Co-Creator Lab to explore how AI can support ideation and design.

Instructions:

1. Introduce students to AI tools like Adobe Firefly
2. Students write prompts to generate:
   - A campaign tagline
   - A sample image or visual concept
3. They evaluate the AI outputs and refine them manually.

Activity 2 (Bonus - Senior Build): Discuss ethical considerations of using AI in creative work.

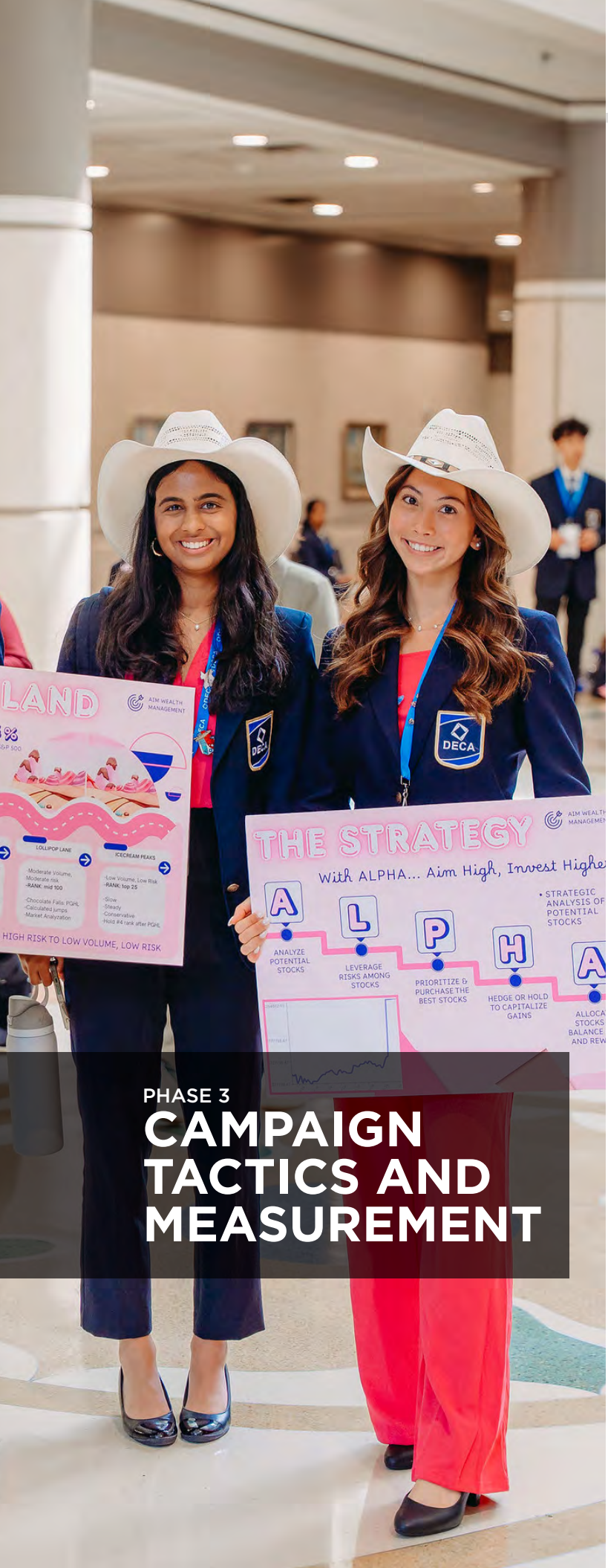
AI Guidance and Resources:

- Responsible generative AI
- AI Ethics: Everything you need to know

PHASE 3:
CAMPAIGN TACTICS AND MEASUREMENT

Bringing Ideas to Life

DECA x Adobe



PHASE 3

CAMPAIGN TACTICS AND MEASUREMENT

Now that students have a strong creative idea, it is time to bring it to life through strategic execution.

Depending on the tactics the campaign will use, the Media Planner, Event Planner, and Web Designer/Developer will lead their respective parts of the project in this section. The development of timelines and budgets is supported by the Project Manager.



PHASE 3

CHANNELS AND TACTICS

This section helps them identify the most effective marketing channels and tailor tactics that align with their audience and campaign objectives.

Key Definitions

- **Channel:** Where the campaign appears (TikTok, campus events, email).
- **Tactic:** What you do in that channel (influencer challenge, AR try-on, pop-up booth, interactive poll).
- **Paid media:** Media placements you pay for to promote your content or message like digital ads, influencer sponsorships, or promoted posts. Example: Running a paid TikTok ad to drive awareness for your campaign.
- **Earned media:** Exposure you earn through word of mouth, press coverage, or public interest without paying directly. Example: A local news outlet writing about your campaign or someone sharing it voluntarily.
- **Shared media:** Content shared on social platforms where interaction and re-sharing happen like reposts, comments, or collaborations with audiences. Example: Campaign content shared and tagged on Instagram or TikTok by your target audience.
- **Owned media:** Channels your brand or organization controls directly like websites, email newsletters, or branded social media accounts. Example: Posting campaign content on your client's Instagram or website.

Teaching Framework

A. Audience Fit

What it means: Select channels based on actual audience usage patterns, not personal preferences.

Why it matters: Miss the channel, miss the audience. Gen Z behavior skews mobile, video, and community-driven; Gen Alpha is deeply interactive and game/AR oriented.

Example: e.l.f. met Gen Z beauty fans on TikTok with #eyeslipsface, generating billions of views by leaning into native creator behavior.

Teaching tip: Have students map "Where our persona scrolls in a day" and circle top 2–3 platform priorities.

B. Message Fit

What it means: Match the format to the message. Short, remixable content = TikTok; try-on = AR/Snap; deeper education = YouTube/long-form or email.

Why it matters: Platform norms shape engagement; misfit content underperforms.

Example: Barbie's AR Dreamhouse Lenses on Snapchat let users virtually try on film-inspired outfits and transform landmarks which was perfect for playful, visual hype ahead of the movie release.

Teaching tip: For each tactic, students label the content mode: quick hit, immersive, instructional, community-building.

C. PESO Integration (Paid / Earned / Shared / Owned)

What it means: Show how paid placements, influencer or press mentions, social engagement, and owned assets (site/app/email) reinforce each other.

Why it matters: Integrated campaigns multiply reach and credibility; DECA judges reward linkage across touchpoints.

Example: Sprite Limelight pairs creator/artist content (earned + shared) with owned storytelling microsites and regionally activated content drops, extending life far beyond one paid ad burst.

Teaching tip: Provide a blank 2x2 PESO grid—students must place at least one tactic in each quadrant (or explain why not).

D. Sequenced Engagement

What it means: Order matters when rolling out a campaign. Use teaser content to spark awareness, interactive challenges to drive participation, and owned channels to capture leads or conversions.

Why it matters: When tactics build on each other, conversion increases, and storytelling deepens.

Example: Gucci's limited-time Gucci Garden on Roblox launched during the brand's centennial, drawing visits into an immersive world that later extended into longer-lived Gucci Town experiences—an example of sequenced community building.

Teaching tip: Ask: "What happens after someone participates in your challenge? Where do you send them next?"



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Activity 1: Assign each group one of the audience personas they developed in Phase 1 (e.g., “Amira, 17, varsity soccer + TikTok heavy” or “Jay, 12, Roblox + YouTube Kids”).

Teams will select three media channels and identify one key tactic for each, ensuring all are clearly connected to their Creative Big Idea.

Activity 2 (Bonus - Senior Build):

Teams build a Channel Journey Funnel: Awareness ➪ Engagement ➪ Conversion. For each stage, choose one primary channel, one supporting channel, and the handoff between them (e.g., TikTok challenge drives swipe to landing page sign-up).

Student Slide Requirements

- Table: Channel | Tactic | Goal | Why Fit?
- Example asset mockups (screenshots, sketches)
- PESO map (optional but recommended)



PHASE 3

TIMELINE AND BUDGET

A realistic timeline shows when campaign activities launch and how long they run. A budget allocates resources to tactics and should reflect priority, reach, and expected impact.

Teaching Framework

A. Phase Planning

What it means: Organize campaign into stages—Pre-Launch (tease), Launch (go live), Sustain (keep momentum), Wrap/Report (measure + next steps).

Why it matters: Campaigns fail when everything drops at once or runs out of steam. Phasing supports learning, optimization, and resource control.

Example: Sprite Limelight rolls out in seasons with artists teased in advance, music content drops at launch, fan participation and remixes sustain engagement, showing structured phasing in action.

Teaching tip: Use a wall timeline with sticky notes; have students physically place tactics in sequence.

B. Moment Alignment

What it means: Tie timing to cultural, seasonal, or brand milestones (e.g. anniversaries, film releases, holidays, school calendars).

Why it matters: Riding cultural waves increases organic reach and relevance—critical when budgets are small.

Example: Gucci's two-week Gucci Garden Roblox event synchronized with its 100th anniversary and immersive exhibit launch, creating urgency and cultural talk value.

Teaching tip: Ask students to add a "Why this date?" note beside each major campaign milestone.

C. Budget Prioritization

What it means: Allocate more spend to highest-impact tactics; trim "nice to have" items. Include rough cost assumptions.

Why it matters: Shows business thinking; DECA judges value financial justification.

Example: e.l.f.'s early TikTok investment in creator-led audio and participation delivered outsized earned reach relative to paid media outlay—illustrating how smart targeting can stretch budget.

Teaching tip: Give cost ranges (micro-influencer post, student video production, printing) so students practice trade-offs.

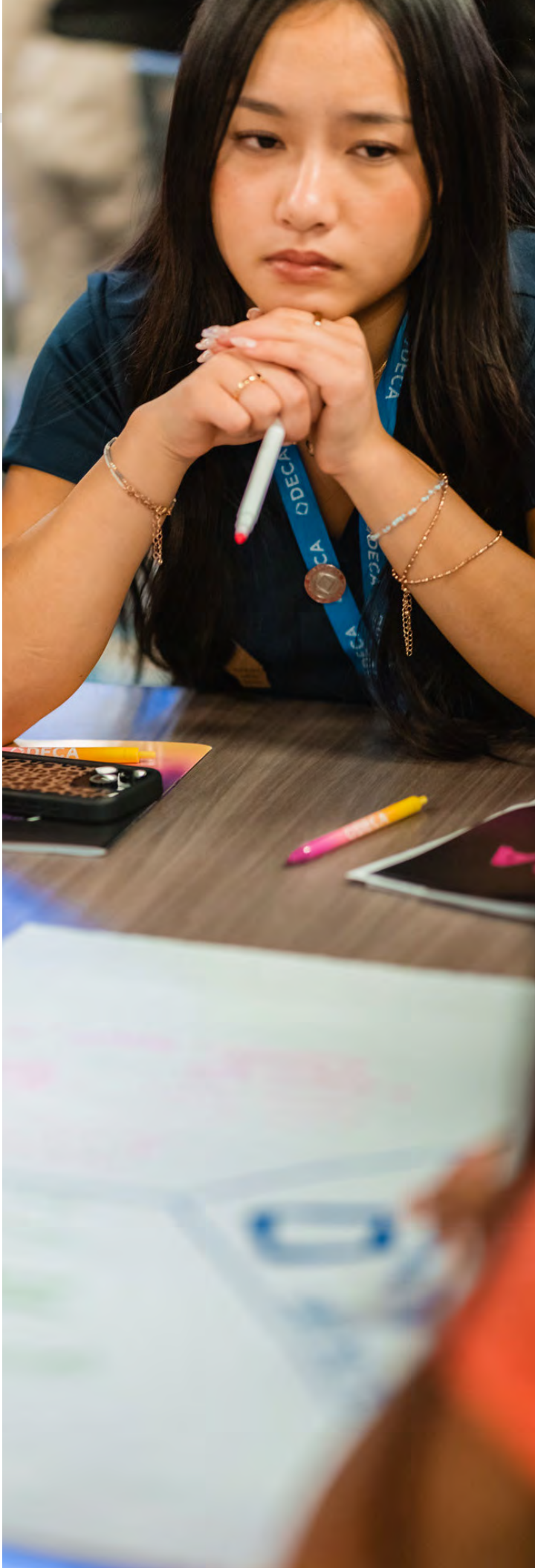
D. Scenario Flexing

What it means: Plan how to reallocate if budgets shrink or if something overperforms and deserves more funding.

Why it matters: Real marketing plans change; adaptability demonstrates maturity.

Example: Many cross-platform entertainment tie-ins (see Barbie AR rollout) layered assets over time, allowing additional geographic landmark
activations as buzz grew.

Teaching tip: Run "What if?" drills: -35% budget; +$2K windfall; supplier delay; content goes viral, now what?





CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Activity 1: Teams get a $10,000 fictional budget and a 6-week runway.

They phase their tactics and assign costs. Require at least one low-cost earned/shared element.

Activity 2 (Bonus- Senior Build):

Provide three budget scenarios ($10K base / $6.5K cut / +$2K stretch). Teams produce a tri-tier budget table showing what stays, what goes, and what scales.

Student slide requirements

- Timeline (Gantt, calendar, phased bars)
- Budget summary (table or pie chart)
- Cost assumptions + notes (1–2 bullets)
- Scenario “If cut…” note (optional, strong for top teams)



PHASE 3

MEASUREMENT AND KPIS

KPIs (Key Performance Indicators) are the metrics used to determine whether the campaign met its objectives. Students must tie each KPI to a stated goal and show how data will be collected.

Teaching Framework

A. Goal Alignment

What it means: Every KPI must map directly to an objective: Awareness ⇨ reach/impressions; Engagement ⇨ shares/comments; Conversion ⇨ sign-ups, downloads, sales.

Why it matters: Random metrics = weak story. Clear alignment shows strategic discipline.

Example: Duolingo links viral TikTok moments to downstream app engagement, tracking when spikes in social attention correlate with self-reported “heard about us on TikTok” and install lift.

Teaching tip: Create a 2-column worksheet: Goal | Metric. Have students fill it in before building slides.

B. Metric Quality (Leading vs. Lagging)

What it means: Leading indicators suggest future success (video completion, early sign-ups). Lagging indicators confirm outcomes (total conversions and sales).

Why it matters: Helps teams optimize mid-campaign instead of waiting for results.

Example: Nike's "Play New" tracked content engagement and sentiment signals (leading) in addition to reputation/brand lift over time (lagging), reflecting a shift from elite to inclusive positioning.

Teaching tip: Use colored dots: green = leading, blue = lagging. Students must include at least one of each.

C. Data Source & Feasibility

What it means: Students should identify where data comes from (TikTok Analytics, Google Forms survey, coupon scans, attendance counts).

Why it matters: Judges expect realism; if the metric can't be captured by students, pick a different one.

Example: Sprite Limelight's multi-artist program lives across music and social platforms; stream counts, video views, and engagement data are trackable across owned + partner channels.

Teaching tip: Require a "Data Source" column in the KPI table.

D. Benchmarking & Targets

What it means: A KPI is stronger with a numeric target (e.g., 5K views in 2 weeks) and—ideally—a comparison point (school size, prior year, platform averages).

Why it matters: Numbers make performance defensible and presentation credible.

Example: Aerie has long tied its #AerieREAL positioning to measurable business and brand outcomes including reported sales lifts linked to its body-positive messaging, illustrating how values-led campaigns can track impact.

Teaching tip: Give students baseline estimates (total school enrollment, average club post reach) to help them set realistic targets.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Activity 1: Show a sample goal (“Increase sign-ups for sustainable hydration challenge”).

Students brainstorm 5 metrics; class votes on which 3 are most aligned & measurable.

Activity 2 (Bonus - Senior Build):

Teams create a Mini Reporting Framework:

- 1 Leading Indicator
- 1 Lagging Indicator
- Mid-campaign optimization trigger (“If engagement <2%, shift $ to influencer boost”).
- Student Slide Requirements
- KPI table: Goal | Metric | Target | Data Source | Timing
- Optional sample dashboard mock (Excel-style bar or gauge)



PHASE 3

CONCLUSION AND CALL TO ACTION

The final part of your pitch deck reinforces the campaign's value and asks for action whether that's approval, funding, adoption, and/or audience participation.

Teaching Framework

A. Restate the Value

What it means: Briefly remind the audience of the challenge, the insight, and how the campaign solves it.

Why it matters: Judges may have seen many pitches, so the closing recap helps retention.

Example: Aerie's #AerieREAL communications routinely circle back to the brand's long-term commitment to unretouched, inclusive representation, reminding audiences why the platform exists and how it continues to deliver commercial and cultural value.

Teaching tip: Use a 3-bullet recap template: Challenge / Idea / Impact.

B. Confident Voice

What it means: Use assertive, positive language ("This campaign will…" rather than "We hope…").

Why it matters: Confidence influences perceived credibility; evaluators respond to clear recommendations.

Example: Patagonia's "Don't Buy This Jacket" campaign closed with a bold, unexpected statement that reinforced their brand values and immediately captured attention. The call to action—think before you buy—was assertive, aligned, and entirely brand-authentic.

Teaching tip: Practice reading closers aloud; have peers flag hedging words ("maybe," "try," "hopefully").

C. Action Direction

What it means: Tell the audience exactly what you want: approve budget, partner with school clubs, scan code to join challenge, follow social handle.

Why it matters: Clear next steps to improve adoption and scoring under DECA effectiveness criteria.

Example: Apple's "Shot on iPhone" campaign closes each piece of content with a clean, bold statement that doubles as a call to action. It reinforces product confidence while inviting users to go create. The CTA is built right into the brand language.

Teaching tip: Require one decision CTA (for judges/brand) and one audience CTA (for end users).

D. Emotional Finish

What it means: End with an image, statement, or stat that reinforces the campaign's emotional core.

Why it matters: Last impressions stick; emotional resonance drives recall in judging.

Example: Google's "Loretta" ad concludes with an emotional gut punch: a widower asking Google to remember his favorite things about his late wife. It ends not with a product pitch but a profound feeling, showing how an emotional finish can create lasting impact.

Teaching tip: Encourage teams to choose one powerful final visual instead of a dense text slide.



CLASSROOM ACTIVITY

Activity 1: Each team builds a 1-slide closing recap (Challenge ⇨ Idea ⇨ Impact + CTA) and delivers a 60-second final sell in front of the class.

Peer scoring: Clarity, Confidence, Memorability.

Activity 2 (Bonus - Senior Build):

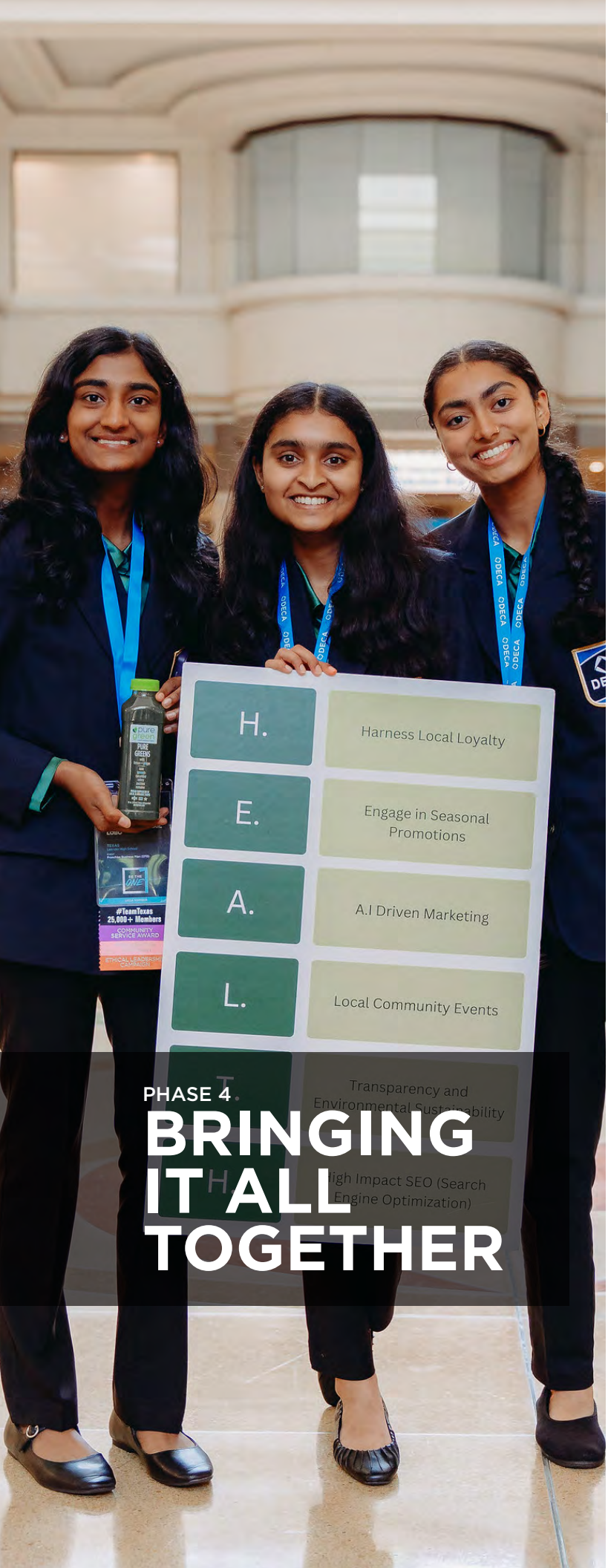
Teams adapt their CTA into three platform formats:

- TikTok voiceover script (10 sec)
- Instagram caption (≤125 chars before “more”)
- Email subject line (≤40 chars)
- Discuss tone shifts across channels.

PHASE 4:
BRINGING IT ALL TOGETHER

Getting Presentation Ready

DECA x Adobe



PHASE 4

BRINGING IT ALL TOGETHER

This is when students gather all the resources they have collected so far and get ready for the competition by building their pitch decks and preparing their presentations.

As the agency team gets ready to pitch their project to their client, the whole team will come together to prepare and present.



PHASE 4

WHY A PITCH DECK?

IMC events revolve around presenting campaign concepts to potential clients just like in the real world. A pitch deck is a short, strategic presentation that outlines an opportunity the agency sees for a product, service, or brand in an attempt to win their business. Using pitch decks in IMC events mirrors industry practice and gives students valuable, hands-on experience.

PITCH DECK GUIDELINES

To ensure consistency and fairness, all pitch decks must follow the guidelines below. Additionally slides must be in a 16:9 aspect ratio and a PDF version of the pitch deck must be uploaded during the ICDC-Qualifying Prepared Entry Submissions window. Teams that do not meet these requirements may receive penalty points.

Section	Requirements	Slide Numbering	Notes
Cover Slide	First slide of the pitch deck	Not numbered "1"	All following slides are numbered in sequence
Title Slide	Name of event, Name of high school, School address, City, State/ Province, ZIP/Postal Code, Names of participants, Date	2	Name of event: INTEGRATED MARKETING CAMPAIGN– EVENT/PRODUCT/ SERVICE
Table of Contents	Single-spaced, only one slide	3	Follows the title slide
Body of the Pitch Deck	Begins with Section I, Overview, continues in outlined sequence	4 and up	Slide numbers continue through bibliography and appendix
Overview	One-slide description of campaign, business need addressed	Sequence after 4	First slide of the body
Description of the Event, Product or Service and Its Company	Description required	Sequence	Section must be titled
Campaign Objectives	Objectives of the campaign	Sequence	Section must be titled
Campaign Target Market	Target market details	Sequence	Section must be titled
Campaign Activities and Schedule	No more than 45 days, creative samples of marketing pieces	Sequence	Section must be titled
Budget	Detailed projections of actual cost	Sequence	Section must be titled
Key Metrics	Key performance indicators to measure campaign success	Sequence	Section must be titled
Bibliography	List of sources used in the pitch deck	Sequence	Required, section must be titled
Appendix	Optional, additional material and exhibits	Sequence	Section must be titled, slides numbered as noted



PHASE 4

PITCH DECK DESIGN BEST PRACTICES

Focus on content:

- Entrepreneurs typically create two types of pitch decks: one with detailed text and information for investors to review by email, and another for in-person presentations that use visuals to engage investors while details are presented verbally.

- As competition pitch decks must be submitted before the presentations, students should focus on content. While creative and compelling visuals that strategically convey the most important content are highly encouraged, drawings, illustrations, and graphic presentations will be judged for clarity, not artistic value.

Resource:

What is a pitch deck — examples and templates to create yours today."
Read the blog from Adobe to learn how Express can help students design their pitch decks.

Follow design guidelines:

Visual appeal

- Use consistent fonts, colors, and spacing. Incorporate high-quality images, charts, and infographics to make them visually engaging and easy to digest.
- Avoid too many graphics or busy backgrounds.
- Consider using Adobe Express templates and Adobe Stock images to enhance design and clarity. First-place teams at DECA's International Career Development Conference (ICDC) that demonstrate significant use of Adobe Express in their pitch deck and presentation will earn $5,000 per team. Following ICDC, these teams will participate in a brief (5–10 minute) live Zoom call to showcase the impact of Adobe Express in their project and answer questions.
- Limit text: With text, less is more. Be concise and straightforward. Slides should convey clear messages using bullet points and visuals rather than dense text.

Tell a story

While the body of the pitch deck must be structured per the guidelines, try to make the presentation of it flow like a compelling narrative. The emotional connection can be more impactful than a dry list of metrics.

Follow the rubric

While there is no separate rubric for the pitch deck, students should ensure that all line items in the Presentation Evaluation Form are addressed in the pitch deck in the best way possible to achieve maximum score.





PHASE 4

PRESENTING YOUR PITCH

This is the moment competitors have been working toward presenting their projects to the judges, who students should consider as the brand clients for this pitch. It is the culmination of weeks of research, strategy, and refinement, all leading to this opportunity to showcase their integrated marketing campaigns and demonstrate a clear understanding of the performance indicators and what success looks like.

A. Presentation guidelines from DECA Guide:

- The participants will present to the judge during a 15-minute presentation worth 100 points.
- The presentation begins immediately after the introduction of the participants to the judge by the adult assistant. Each participant must take part in the presentation.
- Each participant may bring a copy of the pitch deck or note cards pertaining to the pitch deck and use as reference during the presentation.
- If time remains, the judge may ask questions pertaining to the campaign.
- Only visual aids that can be easily hand carried to the presentation by the actual participant(s) will be permitted. The participants themselves must set up the visuals. Wheeled carts, moving straps or similar items may not be used to bring visuals into the

area. Set up time is included in the total presentation time. Participants must furnish their own materials and equipment. No electrical power or internet connection will be supplied. Alternate power sources such as small generators are not allowed. Sound may be used, as long as the volume is kept at a conversational level.

- Materials appropriate to the situation may be handed to or left with judges in all competitive events. Items of monetary value may be handed to but may not be left with judges. Items such as flyers, brochures, pamphlets and business cards may be handed to or left with the judge. No food or drinks allowed.

Rule/Guideline	Details
Presentation Duration	15-minute presentation worth 100 points
Presentation Start	Begins after introduction of participants to judge by adult assistant
Participant Involvement	Each participant must take part in the presentation
Reference Materials	Each participant may bring a copy of the pitch deck or note cards pertaining to the pitch deck
Judge Questions	If time remains, judge may ask questions pertaining to the campaign
Visual Aids	Only hand carried visual aids permitted; participants must set up visuals themselves
Transport Restrictions	No wheeled carts, moving straps or similar items for bringing visuals
Set Up Time	Included in total presentation time
Materials/Equipment	Participants must furnish their own materials and equipment
Power/Internet	No electrical power or internet connection supplied; alternate power sources not allowed
Sound	Sound may be used if volume is kept at conversational level
Materials for Judges	Materials appropriate to the situation may be handed to or left with judges in all competitive events
Items of Monetary Value	May be handed to but not left with judges
Printed Materials	Flyers, brochures, pamphlets and business cards may be handed to or left with the judge
Food/Drinks	No food or drinks allowed

B. Presentation considerations

- **Think of the judges as your brand clients.** In this scenario, act as if the judges are the clients that you need to win over with your pitch.
  - Focus on solving the client's problem. Show that you understand their brand, audience, and challenges and make it clear how your idea directly addresses those.
  - Sell the why, not just the what. Don't just describe your concept; explain the thinking behind it and why it will connect with the target audience and deliver results. Ask yourself: If I were paying for this campaign, what would I want to hear? What would convince me?
- **Be flexible.** Participants may use any visual aids that meet the criteria under Presentation Guidelines for the event when presenting to the judge. This means your uploaded PDF deck is reviewed beforehand, but you can create a more dynamic presentation for the live pitch.
- **Engage the judge.** Start with a hook. Tell a story that captivates their attention and makes them want to learn more.
- **Know your deck cold.** All participants should be able to speak confidently about every slide without reading from it.
- **Manage your time.** Practice your presentation to fit within the allotted 15 minutes of time. Make sure to leave time for the judge to ask questions.
- **Anticipate questions.** Think about potential questions judges might ask and prepare concise, thoughtful answers. Practice Q&A sessions before the competition.
- **Be professional.** Dress professionally, maintain eye contact, speak clearly and confidently, and be enthusiastic.
- **Follow the rubric.**
  - This cannot be understated. You are not just presenting information; you are actively demonstrating to the judge that you meet and exceed every standard they are looking for, using your pitch deck as a powerful visual and structural framework for that demonstration.
  - The Presentation Evaluation Form and the Pitch Deck Guidelines are your blueprint for success. They will help you prioritize specific aspects of your campaign, ensure you are covering all performance indicators, and help you conduct more focused research.
- **Practice judging.**
  - Adopting the judge's mindset is an invaluable tool in preparing for your presentation. By stepping into the judge's shoes, you will see your work from their perspective. You will be able to notice gaps, ineffective delivery, lack of clarity, and other potential deficiencies that are not obvious when you are deeply immersed in your own project.
  - You will also learn to appreciate what truly stands out and what gets lost guiding you to make your own presentation more powerful.



APPENDIX

DECA x Adobe

APPENDIX

GLOSSARY OF TERMS

Term	Definition
AIDA (Awareness, Interest, Desire, Action)	A model showing how customers move from learning about a product to buying it.
ARR (Annual Recurring Revenue)	Yearly income from subscriptions or repeat customers.
B2B (Business-to-Business)	When one company sells to another company.
B2C (Business-to-Consumer)	When a company sells directly to individual customers.
Brand	The identity of a business, product, or service as perceived by the public including its name, logo, values, reputation, and overall image.
Business challenge	A gap, obstacle, or unmet need the brand faces that marketing can help address.
CAC (Customer acquisition cost)	The cost of acquiring a new customer.
Campaign brief	A concise document outlining the strategy and direction for the campaign.
Channel	Where the campaign appears (TikTok, campus events, email).
Competitive set	A subset of the industry; brands that compete for the same target audience.
CTA (Call to Action)	The action you want the audience to take.
Demographics	Statistical traits (e.g., age, income, gender, location).
GTM (Go-to-market)	The plan for launching a product to customers.
Earned media	Exposure you earn through word of mouth, press coverage, or public interest without paying directly.

Term	Definition
Industry	A group of companies offering similar products or services.
Insight	A deep human truth about the audience that informs messaging and tone.
KPI (Key Performance Indicator)	A measurable goal to track success (e.g., number of sign-ups).
Market positioning	How a brand is perceived in relation to its competitors.
Marketing objective	A specific, measurable result the campaign aims to achieve (e.g., increased awareness, sales, or engagement).
Media channels	Platforms used to reach the audience (e.g., social media, radio, podcasts).
Media habits	How and where the audience consumes content.
Owned media	Channels your brand or organization controls directly like websites, email newsletters, or branded social media accounts.
Paid media	Media placements you pay for to promote your content or message like digital ads, influencer sponsorships, or promoted posts.
Persona	A fictional character based on research that represents the audience.
ROI (Return on investment)	How much profit do you make compared to what you spent?
SEO (Search Engine Optimization)	Making your content easier to find on Google.
Psychographics	Values, beliefs, interests, and motivations.
Shared media	Content shared on social platforms where interaction and re-sharing happen like reposts, comments, or collaborations with audiences.
SMART goals	Goals that are Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, and Time-bound.

Term	Definition
SWOT analysis	A framework for identifying a brand's: • Strengths and Weaknesses: Internal factors within the company's control. • Opportunities and Threats: External factors shaped by market or industry forces.
Target audience	The group the campaign aims to influence.
Tactic	What you do in that channel (influencer challenge, AR try-on, pop-up booth, interactive poll).
Tone and voice	The style and personality of brand communication.
USP (Unique selling proposition)	The brand's distinct advantage or benefit that sets it apart from competitors.
UX (User experience)	How easy and enjoyable it is to use a product.
Presentation Duration	15-minute presentation worth 100 points

APPENDIX

RUBRIC ALIGNMENT GUIDE

Use this guide to ensure your Integrated Marketing Campaign addresses all key rubric criteria. Each criterion below maps to a specific section of the campaign guide.

Rubric Criterion	Where to Include in Campaign
Defined Target Market	Phase 1: Situation Analysis or Phase 2: Strategy
Measurable Objectives	Phase 2: Objectives Section
Insight-Driven Strategy	Phase 2: Creative Big Idea and Strategy
Budget Alignment	Phase 3: Budget Slide
Key Performance Indicators	Phase 3: Evaluation Section
Integrated Channels	Phase 2: Tactical Plan
Implementation Timeline	Phase 3: Timeline
Overall Campaign Cohesion	Throughout the Deck; Storyline Consistency
Research and Rationale	Phase 1: Situation Analysis; Phase 2: Strategy
Creative Quality	Phase 2: Creative Big Idea and Tactics

APPENDIX

PRESENTATION EVALUATION FORM

Did the participating team...		Little/No Value	Below Expectation	Meets Expectations	Exceeds Expectations	Judged Score
PERFORMANCE INDICATORS						
1.	Provides a clear overview of the campaign, and explains the business need the campaign is addressing	0-1-2-3	4-5-6	7-8	9-10	
2.	The description of the event, product or service, and business is clearly defined	0-1	2-3	4-5	6	
3.	Objectives are defined and referenced throughout the campaign	0-1-2	3-4-5	6	7-8	
4.	The target market is clearly analyzed	0-1	2-3	4-5	6	
5.	The campaign activities are realistic, show evidence of marketing knowledge, and are research based	0-1-2-3	4-5-6-7	8-9-10	11-12	
6.	Unifying theme is evident in all campaign activities	0-1	2-3	4-5	6	
7.	Provides high-quality appropriate and creative samples of key marketing pieces suggested	0-1-2-3	4-5-6	7-8	9-10	
8.	Campaign schedule is cohesive and plan is no more than 45 days long	0-1-2	3-4-5	6	7-8	
9.	The budget is realistic for the campaign and all costs that would be incurred have been considered	0-1-2	3-4-5	6	7-8	
10.	Key metrics are well thought out and appropriate for the campaign	0-1-2	3-4-5	6	7-8	
11.	The campaign shows evidence of creativity and originality	0-1-2	3-4-5	6	7-8	
12.	The pitch deck is well-organized, professional, and presented in a logical manner	0-1	2-3	4	5	
13.	Overall performance: professional appearance, poise, confidence, presentation technique, effective use of visuals, professionalism of participants, participation by each participant	0-1	2-3	4	5	
TOTAL SCORE (100 points)						

Integrated Marketing Campaign (IMC)

DECA x Adobe